



PARSHA READER

From the Office of Rabbi Joseph Dweck

Parashat Yitro

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Parashat Yitro marks the transition from the physical liberation of Egypt to the spiritual revelation at Sinai. It begins with the arrival of Moshe's father-in-law, Yitro, who recognizes God's greatness and provides essential administrative advice to prevent Moshe from "withering away." This structure sets the stage for the ultimate Preamble: God's offer to Israel to enter into a mutual, meaningful covenantal relationship. The Ten Commandments are presented not just as laws, but as the terms of a joint endeavor to walk together as a God and a People.

The Outsider's Recognition

The Parasha opens with Yitro, Moshe's father-in-law, arriving at the camp with Moshe's wife and sons. After hearing the miraculous accounts of the Exodus and the war with Amalek, Yitro reaches a profound realization:

עתה ידעתי כי גדול ה' מכל האלהים

"Now I know that God is the greatest of all gods."

Yitro observes the poetic justice of the sea—how the Egyptians were met with the very water they used to drown Jewish children. Essentially becoming a convert (*ger*), Yitro recognizes that this God cares for and attends to His people with precision.

- **Circuit Courts:** To handle basic, everyday legal matters.
- **Appellate Courts:** For more complex issues.
- **The Supreme Court:** Moshe himself, reserved only for the most major cases.

This structure allowed the people to get answers quickly without exhausting their leader. Moshe implements this, preparing the nation for the encounter at Sinai.

"God is interested in walking with you in the world... doing this as a joint endeavor."

The Supreme Court Model

Despite his awe, Yitro offers unsolicited but vital advice. He watches Moshe standing from morning until evening to judge the people and warns: *Navol tivol*—"You will surely wither away."

He suggests a system of delegation:

The Divine Preamble

Before the Ten Commandments are uttered, God presents a Preamble. This is not a forced arrangement; it is an offer. Up until now, the relationship was based on the Covenant of the Forefathers (*Brit Avot*). Sinai, however, is a new level: a partnership.

God tells Moshe to ask the people if they want to be His *Am Segula* (treasured people). The point of the Torah is the relationship itself—that God and Israel should walk together in history.

- **Shabbat:** A partnership in creation. We rest together to "allow for being."
- **Interpersonal Sanctity:** Honoring parents, protecting life, marriage, property, and truth.

Terms of the Relationship

After three days of dramatic preparation—thunder, lightning, and the *shofar*—God introduces Himself: *Anochi Adonai Elohecha*. I am the Primal Existence, and I am **your** God.

The Commandments (Terms) follow:

- **Exclusive Loyalty:** No other gods.
- **Sacredness of Name:** Do not take God's name in vain.

Lifting the Bar

The people find the experience so intense they ask Moshe to mediate. God explains that this intensity was to show them their capacity. He warns against "lowering the bar" by making gods of gold and silver.

Instead of making Earth their god, they are to use Earth as a ramp toward Heaven (*Mizbeach Adamah*). The Parasha ends with the promise that wherever God's name is recognized, He will come and bless His people.

Questions for the Table

1. **The Necessity of Structure:** Why did the Torah record Yitro's administrative advice right before the Revelation? What does this teach us about the relationship between "logistics" and "spirituality"?
2. **A Chosen Relationship:** God asks the people for their consent before giving the Torah. Why is the "Preamble" and the "Yes" of the people so crucial to the nature of the Covenant?
3. **Intensity and Growth:** Moshe tells the people that the intensity of Sinai was a test of their capacity. How do we distinguish between an experience that is "too much" and one that is simply challenging us to "lift the bar"?

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